REAL WORLD IMPLEMENTATION / BUSINESS PROCESS AUTOMATION

Policy Lifecycle Management & Workflow Automation

An integrated Microsoft 365 solution that reduced manual policy administration while preserving human compliance review and board approval.

~300	~2 YEARS	POWER AUTOMATE
Policies in scope	Operational use (approx.)	Independently developed workflows

Executive summary

A manual policy review process depended on administrative staff to monitor due dates, distribute policies, track returns, coordinate approval records, and publish updated documents. Absences and competing priorities could interrupt the process; some policies were missed or forgotten. I redesigned the workflow using Excel, Power Automate, email, OneDrive, and SharePoint, with a series of date driven and event driven automations supporting a policy portfolio of approximately 300 records.

The design deliberately retained human checkpoints for evaluating policy content, checking requirements against CARF standards and Oregon Administrative Rules (OAR), confirming operational practice, and preparing materials for board consideration.

Business problem

Person dependent execution. Review requests and tracking relied on an administrator being available to manage every step.

Missed or delayed actions. Policies could be overlooked when manual follow up and document handling fell behind.

Fragmented status information. Review submissions, board approval, and publication required updates across email, document folders, and the tracking register.

Design objective

Automate predictable administrative work, calendaring, reminders, document routing, and status updates, while reserving professional judgment, compliance assessment, and approval decisions for people.

My contribution

I defined the workflow, designed the date logic, built and tested the Power Automate flows, handled exceptions, and maintained the process. I delegated creation of the initial policy tracking spreadsheet to an office specialist with available capacity; the automation architecture and implementation were my responsibility.

TOOLS Excel formulas • Power Automate • Outlook/email • OneDrive • SharePoint • Relias handoff

Solution architecture

Multiple workflows worked together rather than one end to end unattended flow. Scheduled triggers initiated policy requests; incoming emails and document movements triggered downstream steps. Human review and approval gates remained intentionally in the process.

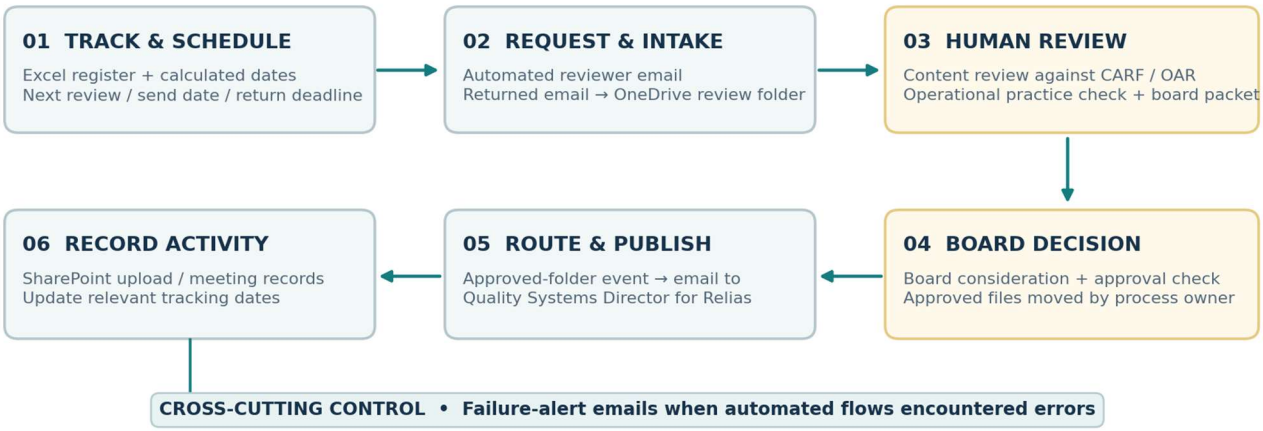


Figure 1. Reconstructed process level design from the original implementation; not an export of the former employer's Power Automate configuration.

How information moved

01 Calculate and initiate -Excel date formulas derived the next review timing from board approval and meeting dates; Power Automate sent review requests on the calculated notification date.

02 Capture returned policies -A reply email triggered a separate workflow to move submitted policy documents into my OneDrive policy review folder and update the submission tracking information.

03 Review before board submission -I assessed content against referenced CARF and OAR requirements and challenged gaps between written procedures and actual practice before assembling the board policy packet.

04 Record decision and route publication -After the board meeting, a confirmation request checked approval status. Approved files were moved to an approved folder, triggering a notice to the Quality Systems Director for Relias upload.

05 Maintain records -SharePoint document activity supported automatic updates to policy upload dates and board review dates when approval documentation was uploaded.

Technical and process design

Central policy register

An Excel based register served as the central record. It paired policy identity and ownership fields with dates that were entered, calculated, or updated by workflow activity.

Information captured	Purpose in the process
Policy number; current / previous name	Maintained identification across policy name changes.
Assigned reviewer; email	Specified accountability and notification destination.
Board approval / last review date	Anchored the next review calculation and tracked governance activity.
Calculated next review; send date; return deadline	Drove review scheduling, 30 day advance distribution, and a return date 10 days before the board meeting.
Review submission date	Captured receipt of policy returned via email.
SharePoint upload date	Recorded policy publication/document upload activity.

Triggers and decision boundaries

Scheduled trigger. A calculated date initiated review email distribution before the next board meeting.

Email event. Returned submissions moved to the OneDrive review folder, with tracking data updated.

Human quality gate. Content checks and board packet assembly were intentionally not automated.

Approval and file move event. Post meeting confirmation preceded the manual movement of approved documents; that folder action initiated the downstream Relias handoff notification.

SharePoint event. Relevant uploaded documents updated the tracking record's board review and upload dates.

Exception handling

I configured failure alert emails to flag interrupted flows. Missing policy returns were followed up manually; I had planned automatic overdue reminders, but that enhancement was not completed. The system therefore combined automated monitoring for technical failures with manual follow up for outstanding reviews.

Implementation, controls & lessons

Testing and rollout

Before directing automated messages to policy reviewers, I tested workflow behavior using my own email account to avoid confusing staff with unverified notifications. I then put the interconnected flows into operational use and maintained them for approximately two years.

A real constraint: Microsoft 365 security settings

Third party IT security controls periodically interrupted Power Automate permissions and required me to reauthorize connections. Because these failures could silently disrupt an administrative deadline, I built email alerts into the flows so I could identify and address errors. This did not eliminate platform dependencies; it provided a practical detection control in the environment available to me.

Human judgment by design

AUTOMATED	HUMAN LED
Scheduled requests • receipt routing • date tracking • approved folder notifications • failure alerts	Substantive policy review • CARF/OAR checks • operational verification • board packet preparation • approval confirmation and action

Operational value and evidence

The implementation replaced several recurring administrative steps with date driven and event driven workflows, supported a portfolio of approximately 300 policies, and remained in use for roughly two years. The design made review timing more systematic and routed documents through defined checkpoints, while leaving compliance and board decisions with accountable people.

No formal baseline or post implementation study measured hours saved, fewer missed reviews, or compliance rate improvement. Those benefits are therefore described as process capabilities and intended risk reductions, not verified numerical outcomes.

What I would strengthen in a future implementation

Automation continuity. Use organization managed connections and shared ownership rather than depending on one individual's account.

Exception escalation. Add documented overdue reminder and escalation rules, with visibility into open items.

Governance and documentation. Maintain a flow inventory, runbook, and documented handoff so the process can survive role changes and account deactivation.

User experience. Consolidate notifications where practical while preserving required review deadlines and accountability.

Capabilities demonstrated

Business process design - • Microsoft Power Automate development • Cross platform document workflows • Excel date logic • Exception monitoring • Compliance operations • Stakeholder coordination • Human centered automation

CASE STUDY NOTE - This is a retrospective, high level reconstruction of an implemented professional system. No former employer data, policy contents, screenshots, or proprietary configurations are reproduced.